BRAND CONSCIOUSNESS

Whether with the people associated with the company or the environment, Samsonite India CEO Jai Krishnan states that being responsible and responsive drives success.



During what's being called the start of a big wave for the branded luggage industry, Samsonite India CEO Jai Krishnan isn't focussing only on leveraging the business. For him, his customers, consumers and planet Earth are equally important. In a freewheeling conversation, he talks about the brand's efforts to succeed but also support dealers and distributors during the COVID-19 pandemic, ethos of being kind to Mother Nature with eco-friendly luggage, and what competition means to a leader.

Besides the business booming, with more than 100 per cent growth and a 50 per cent increase in sales this year, what has been Samsonite India's recent highlight?

In 2022–23, we focused on creating a distinctive positioning to show the strength of bags that are tested rigorously and vigorously. Through the 'Tested like Samsonite' campaign, we showcased the journeys of famous personalities such as Yuvraj Singh, Amitabh Bachchan and Mithali Raj, who have overcome challenges to come out stronger. After the television campaign, the digital phase took some famous personalities, such as drummer Sivamani drumming on the bag. It was called one of the best campaigns ever.

What about American Tourister? Where does that brand stand?

American Tourister's has been a fantastic journey from launch to leadership in the nine years of its existence. Indians love old brands, and this was a reasonably new name in the country, but it picked up quickly. It made a mark in about four years, and in the next five years, it became a leading name. Every year, the gap between American Tourister and the second brand increases. So that's a happy story.

Also, we signed Virat Kohli as our brand ambassador in 2016 before he became 'the' Virat Kohli. It's been a great seven years with him, and when I met him recently, I could feel that bond between the brand and the man. So, we called it right with getting him on board. This year, we will launch a campaign for American Tourister, which we believe will be one of the best.

As the company surges ahead, many businesses are still recovering from the pandemic's repercussions. What held you in good stead?

A strong team that got to work as soon as the lockdown eased and taking the risk of continuing to invest in the business when everyone else was trying to save up. We have 12,000 families associated with Samsonite — vendors, distributors, their families and employees, etc. That's a responsibility I wake up to every day. COVID-19 was the most traumatic phase of my 33-year-long career, but Samsonite India decided to be conscious about all these families. We gave discounts to enable our dealers and vendors to continue selling their stock. Even now, when I meet our partners, they remember we came through during the most challenging times. We may feel proud of our success and numbers, but this has brought us joy. We kept our ears to the ground and keenly listened to what our customers and consumers wanted.

Besides caring for the people associated with the brand, Samsonite India is also known for being eco-conscious…

Yes, the other important pillar of our company has been the love for the planet. I say with immense pride that we've been talking about the planet and what we should do before it became fashionable. We've always made great bags to ensure there are fewer units. We also started repairability globally. Our after-sale service network that believes if a consumer wants a bag repaired, we must do it to prevent the